

A week later, in Arkansas, Confederate General Sterling Price and 12,000 ragtag cavalymen trotted north on a raid into Missouri, where Price had once been governor. They hoped to take that state for the Confederacy, or at least cause a defeat that would harm Lincoln's chances for re-election. Since St. Louis was too well garrisoned to chance an assault, they veered west along the Missouri River's south bank, and Price swept up whatever horses, mules, cattle, and supplies he could find. Price was, however, no Forrest. No doubt alarmed by the fresh scalps he saw hanging from the bridle of the bushwhacker leader "Bloody Bill" Anderson, he failed to deploy Missouri's hordes of Confederate bushwhackers in the Union rear. Above all, Price moved too slowly—after looting the state he was encumbered by a long train of cattle and wagons.

Inevitably, Union troops closed in—35,000 of them. In October, Price made a run west for Kansas and then south for Indian Territory (today's Oklahoma). Pitched battles occurred as he tried to ford swollen rivers. On October 23, at Westport near Kansas City, he repeatedly charged a Union line but failed to break it before enemy cavalry was at his rear.

Over the next few days, a running fight developed until Price abandoned his booty and fled south. The very day that he crossed the Arkansas River to safety—November 8—was Election Day in the North. Not only had Price's raid failed to capture Missouri for the South, but his ignominious retreat had actually helped Lincoln's victory—an ironic end to the Confederacy's final campaign west of the Mississippi.